

AI 101 — build it, ship it, log it — then your instrument

Lecture 1 • Fri 11 Sep 2026 • 14:20–16:20 • R311 IAMS

Two promises for today:

a page that teaches one idea, on the public web, **before the break** •
your own phone app measuring your ESP32 **by the end**

"ship" = publish it where others can open it • "log" = write down what you did, in plain text

What we build together

One class instrument — an ESP32-S3 dev board (a small WiFi computer-on-a-chip, on a board with USB and pins) on a class board with **five blocks**, one per student:

- **B1** precision inputs ($8 \times \pm 10 \text{ V}$, 16-bit)
- **B2** power & rails
- **B3** signal generation ($2 \times \pm 10 \text{ V}$ out)
- **B4** isolated switching (4 relays, 2 optos)
- **B5** digital I/O & timing (5 V TTL, TRIG)

One repository (a project folder whose complete history git keeps, shared on GitHub) `class-board-2026` , **one phone app**, **one Python client**.

You read your block, route it (draw its copper tracks), write its driver and demo it.

The board is ordered **Mon 28 Sep** from everyone's pull requests (your changes, reviewed and merged into the shared project). Boards back $\approx$ 12 Oct. Demos week of 26 Oct.

Why we start away from the project

AI-assisted work is a **general skill**. The same three moves serve a simulation, a website, a video, a report, a KiCad board, a firmware driver:

Build — from a written spec

Ship — where others can see it

Log — what you did, in plain text

Today, twice:

1. **teach one idea you know** — EM, electronics, mechanics, PID — to a high-school student: a page, a simulation, a game. The answer is known before the code exists.
2. the **ESP32 in your hand** — a phone app that measures something. The answer is not known yet.

Electronics design is *one* application of AI,
not the syllabus

The one-sentence thesis

An AI agent is a **junior engineer with no memory**.

It is exactly as good as the project documentation, the task specification and the verification you give it.

Everything today follows from that sentence.

Agent — Claude Code working on your files: it reads them, writes code, runs commands and reports back.

The five working practices

1. **Spec first.** Requirements live in `SPEC.md`, not in chat scrollback. Ask for a plan before code.
2. **Teach the repository, not the session.** `CLAUDE.md`: conventions, pinout, build and flash (write firmware to the board) commands, how to test. Written once, loaded every session.
3. **Small, fresh sessions.** One task = one session. Finish, commit (save a snapshot), start clean. Long sessions rot.
4. **Handover notes.** `PROGRESS.md` at the end of every session: done / verified / next / gotchas.
5. **AI writes, you verify.** No verification plan → not yours to ship.

Words you will hear today

- **repository** — a project folder whose complete history git keeps; on GitHub it also lives online
- **GitHub** — the website where repositories are stored and shared
- **commit** — save a snapshot of your changes with a one-line message
- **push** — upload your commits to GitHub
- **pull request (PR)** — a request to merge your changes into the shared project; someone reviews it first
- **clone** — download a full copy of a repository to your laptop
- **Markdown** — plain text with light formatting (# headings, - lists)
- **agent** — Claude Code working on your files: reads them, writes code, runs commands, reports back
- **deploy** — publish the page so it is live on the web
- **firmware** — the program that runs on the microcontroller
- **flash** — write the firmware onto the board over USB
- **toolchain** — the compiler and helper programs that turn source code into firmware
- **access point** — the board's own WiFi network, which your phone joins
- **the check** — one result you can work out by hand before any code exists, which the finished page must reproduce

Markdown is your lab notebook

PROGRESS.md , SPEC.md , notes.md , README.md , this deck, the workbook — all plain text with light formatting.

- it **diffs** and lives in git (the tool that records a folder's history) next to the code
- it is **searchable** and readable on a phone, on GitHub, in ten years
- the AI **reads it first** at the start of the next session
- the lingua franca of AI work: specs, logs, slides, reports

2026-09-11 — session 1

- Done: rc-filter teaching page from SPEC.md; deployed to <https://rc-filter-xxxx.pages.dev>
- Verified: f_c 1591 Hz (pred. 1591.5), -3.0 dB / -45° there; sliders work on my phone
- Next: the teaching questions grade the answer; RLC as idea two
- Gotchas: Cloudflare output directory must be "/"

"Verify" means a number or an observation

Today	Later
Is f_c where $\mathbf{1/(2\pi RC)}$ said it would be?	Does DRC (KiCad's design rule check) say 0 ?
Does s_d fall as $\mathbf{1/\sqrt{N}}$ on your phone — and if not, why?	Does the scope show $\pm 5.00\text{ V}$?

"It looks right" is not verification. "It works" is not verification.
Write the number down. That is the whole trick.

The loop in miniature — today's two exercises

E1a • Build

your topic, your repository • five-line `SPEC.md` — learner outcome + one result worked out by hand before the code exists • plan • one `index.html` • the check • commit

E1b • Ship + log

push • Cloudflare Pages • URL on your phone • `PROGRESS.md` • push → redeploys itself

E2 • Your phone app measures your ESP32

one command out • mean + sd back • flash • sd vs N against $1/\sqrt{N}$ — explain the difference • branch • pull request (PR) with the numbers

Nobody leaves without it.

Cloudflare Pages — a free service that turns a repository into a public web page • branch — a separate line of work inside a

E1a — build: teach one idea to a high-school student

Pick a topic you know — EM • electronics • classical mechanics • PID • your research. Build the thing that teaches it: a page with sliders and a live plot, a simulation, a game.

```
gh repo create <you>/rc-filter --public --clone && cd rc-filter && code .
```

`gh` is GitHub's command-line tool. `--public` or `--private` — your choice. Cloudflare Pages deploys private repositories too; the GitHub Pages fallback needs a public one.

You write `SPEC.md` — **five lines:** what the learner can do afterwards • what it shows • **the check: one result you can work out by hand before any code exists** ($1\text{ k}\Omega$, 100 nF $\rightarrow f_c = 1591.5\text{ Hz}$, -3 dB , -45°) • a teaching check (a question with a hidden answer) • one file, canvas + JS, no framework, no build, works on a phone.

Then: *"Read SPEC.md. Plan in five bullets. Then write index.html."* Reject a plan that draws a picture instead of computing the physics. Open it. **Read your number off the**

E1b — ship + log

1. `git push -u origin main`
2. Cloudflare → **Workers & Pages** → **Create** → **Pages** → **Connect to Git** → your repository → build command *blank*, output `/` → Deploy
3. Open `https://rc-filter-xxxx.pages.dev` **on your phone**. Move a slider. Send it to a non-physicist.
4. **You** write `PROGRESS.md`: done / verified / next / gotchas. Commit, push — and watch it redeploy itself.

Fallback: GitHub → Settings → Pages → branch main. That is continuous deployment (every push publishes itself); you just did it. This repository is your course page from now on.

Break

When we come back: join your board's WiFi.

The instrument on your phone

Your board is an **access point** (its own WiFi network): LED blue → phone joins `instrument-XXXX` (password `instrument`) → <http://192.168.4.1> → tap *Red*.

firmware on the ESP32-S3

↑↓ one **WebSocket** (a live two-way connection)

phone app (a web page the board serves)

↑↓ same messages

`instrument.py` in Python on a PC

phone → board, one JSON message (plain-text structured data):

```
{"block": "base", "cmd": "led", "args":  
{"r": 255, "g": 0, "b": 0}}
```

board → phone, one reply

board → everyone, **20 × per second**:

status numbers → the chart, the alarms

The two files a control touches

firmware/src/blocks/base/BaseBlock.cpp

```
if (strcmp(c, "led") == 0) {  
    r_ = a["r"] | r_; g_ = a["g"] | g_; b_ = a["b"] | b_;  
    showLed();  
    reply["r"] = r_; ... return true;  
}  
// status(): out["counter"] = counter_;
```

host/pwa/panels/base.js

```
btn.onclick = () =>  
    api.send('base', 'led', { r, g, b });  
// onStatus(st):  
els.counter.textContent = st.counter;
```

A command is **one** `if` **and one button**. A number is **one** `out[...]` **and one** `<span>` .

E2 — your phone app measures something on your ESP32

One command out, one live measurement back — with its noise. Default recipe (workbook § A.4):

1. `BaseBlock.h` : a 1000-sample ring buffer (a fixed-size list that overwrites its oldest entry), `adcN_ = 16` , `adcV_` , `adcSd_`
2. `loop()` : every 1000 μs `analogReadMilliVolts(4)` into the ring; mean and sd over the last N — **no** `delay()`
3. `handle()` : `set_avg {n}` (1...1000) • `status()` : `adc_v` , `adc_sd` , `avg_n`
4. `panels/base.js` : an **N** input + *Set* $\rightarrow$ `api.send('base','set_avg',{n})` ; two readouts filled in `onStatus`
5. `pio run -e esp32s3-sim -t upload && pio run -e esp32s3-sim -t uploadfs`

6. **Verify against a prediction:** sd for $N = 1, 4, 16, 64, 256$. White noise says $1/\sqrt{N}$. It

The class board

Block	What	Parts
B1	$8 \times \pm 10 \text{ V}$ 16-bit inputs, ADS8688	≈ 32
B2	USB-C / 5 V jack $\rightarrow$ +5V, +3V3, $\pm 12 \text{ V}$, +5VA	≈ 20
B3	$2 \times \pm 10 \text{ V}$ outputs, DAC8563 + OPA2192	≈ 15
B4	4 relays, 2 isolated inputs	≈ 24
B5	$8 \times 5 \text{ V}$ TTL out, TRIG in/out	≈ 15

Front panel, **3 × 4 SMA at 20 mm:**

A01 A02 TRIG AUX

AI1 AI2 AI3 AI4

AI5 AI6 AI7 AI8

Base (instructor): dev-board socket, buses, LED, Qwiic, expansion header. JLC (JLCPCB, the factory that makes and assembles our boards) assembles everything; you solder nothing.

Your block — volunteers first, then lots

Five names, five blocks. From now on:

- you **read** it (two questions and one design number this week)
- you **route** it (week 2, your zone of the PCB — the printed circuit board layout)
- you **write its driver and panel** (week 3, in sim mode — the firmware fakes its hardware, so it runs on the bare dev board)
- you **measure one number** on it and **demo** it (Oct)

The tutor writes your block into `PROGRESS.md` and opens your block page.

Beyond the baseline

The **hardware is the shared baseline** — fixed by budget and timeline; JLC builds it.
The **software, firmware and app are open**. That is where you show what you can do.

Whenever you are ahead, the question is: *what problem in my lab could this instrument solve?*

- a **data logger** to CSV that a tool of yours reads • **LINE / Telegram alerts** from the alarm engine
- **remote access** + a **Python sweep** overnight • a **calibration routine** on the board
- a **PID / controller block** — today's PID page, made real • a **second node** (S3-CAM on a gauge)

Bring a real problem to Lecture 2; the tutor helps you write its `SPEC.md`. Optional fifth item at the demo.

Homework 1

- [] **E2 finish + merge** — merge (bring your branch into the main line) once reviewed
- [] **E3 read your block** — V3, two answers **and the design number** in `notes.md`
- [] **E4 KiCad ready** — V4, install KiCad 10 (the part library is in the repository), screenshot your zone
- [] **E5 your SPEC paragraph** — what, **the number you will measure**, how you show it
- [] **reading** — workbook ch. C (git, KiCad); ch. A where needed

`/tutor HW1` paces it; stuck? ask it for the fix. Email the instructor after that.

Every work session ends with `PROGRESS.md` + commit — your day-1 repository and the class repository alike.

Next Friday: your part of the board

Electronics 101 on **our** schematic (the circuit drawing) • KiCad's six operations • place your missing parts • route your zone • your first PR into the class board

Before then: HW1, KiCad 10 installed, the project open.